

**The Surprising Power of Sadness in Workplace Conflict:
When Vulnerability Outperforms Dominance**

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Abstract

Workplace conflict creates an emotional dilemma: employees may need to signal that a violation has occurred, yet they often fear that expressing negative emotions will make them appear unprofessional or difficult to work with. This research investigates how expressing anger, expressing sadness, or choosing not to respond during workplace conflict shapes observers' evaluations. Drawing on the emotions-as-social-information (EASI) model, we argue that observers infer from an emotion expression what it conveys about the expresser's control, standards, intentions, and capacity for repair. Calm, behavior-focused anger can signal agency without implying hostility or loss of control; tempered sadness can signal relational harm, disappointment, and commitment to shared standards without implying weakness; silence, though seemingly restrained, withholds the social information the target needs to recognize and repair the conflict. Two experiments tested effects on instrumental outcomes (agency, effectiveness, behavior change, status) and relational outcomes (likability, appropriateness). In Study 1, tempered sadness achieved roughly 90% of calm anger's perceived effectiveness while matching it on appropriateness and exceeding it on likability; withholding emotion was rated least effective. Study 2 manipulated the expresser's gender. Contrary to stereotypes penalizing "angry women" or "sad men," gender did not moderate instrumental outcomes; the only reliable difference was relational, with sadness rated especially appropriate when expressed by women. These findings suggest that the contextual fit of an emotion display, rather than dominance or gender, shapes social evaluation in modern workplaces.

Keywords: workplace conflict; emotion expression; anger; sadness; emotions as social information (EASI); gender

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Introduction

Workplace conflicts often create an emotional dilemma. Emotion expressions significantly shape workplace conflicts and interpersonal relationships: they project judgment (Cheshin, 2020; Van Kleef, 2008), convey information that others use to interpret intentions and competence (Van Kleef & Côté, 2018), and shape whether a conflict escalates or resolves (Kalter et al., 2021). In many organizational cultures, however, negative emotion expressions such as anger and sadness are perceived as inappropriate or counterproductive (Cheshin, 2020). Employees often fear that expressing negative emotions will make them look unprofessional or out of control, and many remain silent in order to appear professional. But is suppressing negative emotion really the more effective choice?

We examine how expressing anger, expressing sadness, or choosing not to respond to a typical kind of workplace conflict shapes perceptions of the instrumental and relational aspects of interpersonal dynamics.

Traditional emotion theories view emotions as adaptive action tendencies (Frijda, 1986; Lazarus, 1991). In the workplace, anger is often associated with dominance, leadership, and agency (Tiedens et al., 2000), while sadness is often associated with vulnerability and lower status (Brescoll & Uhlmann, 2008). Van Kleef's (2009) emotions-as-social-information (EASI) model suggests, however, that the social consequences of emotion depend heavily on appropriateness and observer inferences. Although anger triggers dominance inferences, it can also elicit defensiveness (Fischer & Roseman, 2007). Conversely, sadness can trigger communal

inferences and empathic affect, potentially serving as a means of connection rather than merely a signal of weakness (Del Rosario et al., 2025; Sinaceur et al., 2015).

The form of expression can be crucial. Research indicates that high-intensity anger often backfires, whereas calm, behavior-focused anger can increase perceptions of agency (Gibson et al., 2009). In parallel, controlled sadness may evoke sympathy, whereas uncontrolled weeping may be seen as unprofessional (Cheshin, 2020; Van Doorn et al., 2015). Thus, we posit that the specific manner of an emotion expression dictates its effectiveness.

Moreover, scholars have long documented a “backlash effect” in which agentic women are penalized for expressing anger (Brescoll & Uhlmann, 2008; Heilman et al., 2004), paralleling the penalty men can face for expressing the gender-incongruent emotion of sadness. Recent research suggests, however, that these gendered scripts may be evolving. As workplaces increasingly value emotional intelligence and authenticity (Hamedani et al., 2024), contextual appropriateness may override gender stereotypes.

Theoretical Background and Hypotheses

Two theoretical accounts offer competing predictions about which emotional response best serves an employee confronting a coworker’s violation. Dominance-based accounts treat emotion expressions as signals of rank: anger communicates strength, competence, and a willingness to impose costs, and accordingly earns the expresser status and influence, whereas sadness communicates submission and earns neither (Tiedens, 2001; Tiedens et al., 2000). On this view, the instrumental benefits of confrontation belong to anger, and sadness offers a confrontation without force. Appraisal-based and social-functional accounts suggest a different logic. Emotions arise from appraisals of the situation – anger from blaming another agent for a goal-blocking offense, sadness from the experience of loss or harm (Fischer & Roseman, 2007;

Lazarus, 1991; Smith & Ellsworth, 1985) – and expressing them transmits those appraisals to observers. The emotions-as-social-information (EASI) model formalizes this transmission by positing that expressed emotions influence observers through an inferential channel, in which observers extract information about the expresser’s standards, intentions, and control, and an affective channel, in which the expression evokes emotional reactions such as sympathy or irritation, with the appropriateness of the expression in context determining which channel dominates and whether reactions are favorable (Van Kleef, 2008, 2009, 2010; Van Kleef & Côté, 2018). From this perspective, what matters is not which emotion is displayed but whether the display fits the situation and what information it carries.

Instrumental and Relational Evaluations

The two channels of the EASI model map onto two families of observer evaluations, paralleling the fundamental dimensions of social judgment (Fiske et al., 2002). Instrumental evaluations concern whether the response works: whether it is effective, whether it will change the target’s future behavior, how much agency it signals, and how much status the expresser deserves. Relational evaluations concern whether the response is socially acceptable: whether it is appropriate to the situation and how likable it makes the expresser. We selected six outcomes to represent these families – predicted behavior change, perceived effectiveness, perceived agency, and perceived status (instrumental); and perceived appropriateness and likability (relational) – each drawn from prior research on emotion perception and workplace behavior (Brescoll & Uhlmann, 2008; Diefendorff et al., 2011; Tiedens, 2001; Van Kleef & Côté, 2018). We classify perceived status as instrumental a priori because status conferral research treats status as a resource observers grant to those they judge capable of getting results (Tiedens, 2001; Tiedens et al., 2000), while acknowledging that status is conferred by others and therefore carries

a relational component as well (see Limitations). Distinguishing the two families matters because the competing accounts diverge most sharply across them: dominance accounts predict that anger wins instrumentally at a relational price and that sadness loses on both fronts, whereas the EASI account predicts that any contextually appropriate expression can succeed instrumentally, and that expressions signaling care for the relationship can succeed relationally at little instrumental cost.

The Form of Expression

If observers evaluate expressions through appraisal and appropriateness rather than emotion category alone, then the form an expression takes should matter as much as the emotion it conveys. Anger delivered calmly and aimed at the offending behavior signals high standards and self-control; the same emotion delivered as yelling or a personal attack signals hostility and loss of control, crossing what the dual threshold model calls the impropriety threshold (Averill, 1983; Gibson & Callister, 2010; Gibson et al., 2009; Steinel et al., 2008; Van Kleef, 2016; Van't Riet et al., 2018). Likewise, tempered sadness signals hurt and continued commitment to the relationship, whereas uncontrolled weeping may signal an inability to cope (Cheshin, 2020; Graham et al., 2008; Van Doorn et al., 2015).

Hypothesis 1: Within each response category, controlled, behavior-focused forms of expression will be evaluated more favorably than uncontrolled, person-directed, or indirect forms of the same response.

Expression Versus Silence

Choosing not to respond is common. When Fitness (2000) asked employees to recall a workplace anger episode, 42% reported withdrawing rather than confronting the offender, and 85% of employees in one sample reported having withheld a concern at work at least once

(Milliken et al., 2003; Morrison & Milliken, 2000). Silence is often chosen precisely because it seems safe. From an EASI perspective, however, silence withholds the social information the target needs to recognize that a violation has occurred: no appraisal is transmitted, so the target receives no signal to act on (Frijda, 1986; Van Kleef, 2009). Suppression also carries documented personal and relational costs, including lower social support and closeness (Srivastava et al., 2009) and the strains associated with effortful emotion regulation at work (Grandey, 2003; Hülshager & Schewe, 2011).

Hypothesis 2: Expressing anger or sadness will yield more favorable instrumental evaluations (effectiveness, behavior change, agency, status) than not responding.

Anger Versus Sadness

The two accounts diverge most clearly in their predictions for sadness. Dominance-based accounts predict that sadness signals submission and should therefore fail instrumentally. The appraisal-based view suggests instead that tempered sadness transmits a serious signal – harm has been done to a valued relationship and to shared standards – while evoking sympathy rather than defensiveness through the affective channel (Sinaceur et al., 2015; Van Kleef et al., 2006). Because it neither attacks the person nor violates display norms, tempered sadness should also be judged appropriate and should preserve warmth (Côté & Hideg, 2011; Graham et al., 2008). Anger’s advantage, where it exists, should be confined to the outcomes most closely tied to pressure: behavior change and perceived agency (Fischer & Roseman, 2007; Sinaceur & Tiedens, 2006).

Hypothesis 3: Tempered sadness will be evaluated at least as favorably as calm anger on relational outcomes (appropriateness, likability) while approaching it on instrumental outcomes.

Expresser Gender

Finally, the accounts diverge on gender. Role congruity theory predicts backlash when expressions violate prescriptive gender stereotypes: anger from a woman and sadness from a man are stereotype-incongruent and should be penalized, particularly in male-typed occupations (Brescoll & Uhlmann, 2008; Eagly & Karau, 2002; Heilman et al., 2004; Rudman & Phelan, 2008). The EASI account instead gives primacy to contextual fit: if an expression is clearly appropriate to the violation, observers' evaluations should rest on the expression rather than on the expresser's gender (Van Kleef & Côté, 2018). Recent evidence that gendered emotion norms are loosening is consistent with this prediction (Hammond et al., 2025; Koenig et al., 2011; Porat & Levy Paluck, 2024; Rosette & Tost, 2010). Because a null effect of gender is theoretically meaningful only against a specified alternative, we treat role congruity theory's prediction – an interaction penalizing stereotype-incongruent expressers – as the competing hypothesis.

Hypothesis 4: The expresser's gender will not moderate instrumental evaluations of contextually appropriate anger and sadness expressions.

Overview of the Present Research

This research examines how different forms of anger, sadness, and reasons for choosing not to respond influence interpersonal outcomes in a prototypical coworker conflict. We conducted two experiments to test whether the form of the emotion and the gender of the expresser moderate these effects. Study 1 tests Hypotheses 1 through 3 by comparing the nine expression variants and then the strongest exemplar from each category; Study 2 tests Hypothesis 4 by manipulating the expresser's gender.

Experimental Design

To ensure ecological validity, we first conducted a pilot study ($N = 123$) to validate the conflict vignette, confirming that the scenario – a coworker failing to do their fair share – was perceived as realistic, serious, and emotionally evocative.

Study 1 established baseline perceptions of three forms of anger, three forms of sadness, and three reasons for not responding (nine total variations) without specifying the expresser's gender. The goal was to identify the most effective, contextually appropriate form of each response category.

Study 2 introduced gender as a moderator. Using the highest-rated exemplars from Study 1 (Calm Anger, Tempered Sadness, and Apprehensive Silence), we manipulated the expresser's gender ("Alex" as male vs. female) to test the hypothesis that contextually appropriate emotion expressions can mitigate gender backlash (Hypothesis 4).

Study 1: The Surprising Power of Authentic Expressions

Study 1 was designed to test different forms of anger and sadness across multiple outcome measures used to gauge their interpersonal consequences. Our goal was to evaluate how different forms of emotion expression shape perceptions and to establish a baseline for evaluating the effects of gender explored in Study 2.

Study 1 tested nine responses (three anger, three sadness, three no response) to a serious and common form of coworker conflict: feeling that a coworker is not doing their fair share. Participants read the following scenario, in which the coworkers were referred to generically as Analyst A and Analyst B so that gender would not influence the results:

An investment banking team is working on a pitch book for a prospective client who is interested in acquiring a fast-growing startup business. Pitch books are used to sell the

client on the firm's ability to help its clients accomplish their objectives – in this case, to successfully purchase the startup business. Because this particular startup is growing so quickly, competition to acquire it is intense. There are many components to pitch books, so the responsibility for creating the different components is distributed to different members of the team. Creating pitch books is generally the responsibility of lower-level members of the team. An associate on the team assigns two first-year investment banking analysts to compile comparable transactions the firm has successfully performed for other clients, including detailed financial information about each transaction. The work is tedious, and the two analysts do not have much time to complete the assignment, so they decide to split the work. The evening before they have to send the information to the associate, Analyst A finds out that Analyst B has barely completed their portion of the assignment. Since Analyst B has already left the office and Analyst A cannot reach them, Analyst A stays all night to complete the assignment. Analyst A manages to complete the task on time.

Participants were randomly assigned to one of nine conditions, each pairing this vignette with one of nine possible responses by Analyst A. After reading the vignette and Analyst A's response, participants rated how angry and sad they thought Analyst A was; how appropriate, effective, agentic, and likable they thought Analyst A's response was; and how likely they thought it was that Analyst B would change their behavior in the future. The responses within each category varied in tone and intensity, allowing us to study differences within each category as well as differences between categories. Within each category, different forms of expression tended to yield different results. These differences were most pronounced for anger, more modest for sadness, and negligible for no response.

The nine responses were as follows (the response selected from each category for Study 2 is *italicized*).

Anger

Anger 1. Analyst A feels angry and tells Analyst B that this behavior is not acceptable.

Analyst A tells Analyst B that they are part of a team, and team members cannot behave like this. Analyst A emphasizes that they want to have a good relationship with Analyst B but also makes it clear that they will not tolerate this behavior in the future.

Anger 2. Analyst A feels angry and yells at Analyst B for not doing their fair share.

Analyst A tells Analyst B that they are an irresponsible person, and any other member of the team would have done their part. Analyst A threatens to tell their boss if it happens again.

Anger 3. Analyst A feels angry and decides to stop talking to Analyst B. Analyst A gives Analyst B dirty looks when they cross paths and ignores Analyst B's attempts to talk.

The social consequences of expressing anger vary depending on qualities such as tone, intensity, and directness (Tiedens, 2001), so we created three responses that varied along those dimensions. We modeled Anger 1 on studies indicating that expressing anger in a calm and behavior-focused manner – rather than with intense, person-directed hostility – increases perceptions of status without incurring significant interpersonal costs (Averill, 1983; Van Kleef, 2016). Thus, in Anger 1, Analyst A calmly “tells” Analyst B, whereas in Anger 2, Analyst A intensely “yells at” Analyst B. Furthermore, in Anger 1, Analyst A states that they want a good relationship with Analyst B, but their *behavior* is not acceptable. In Anger 2, Analyst A makes a *personal* attack on Analyst B by calling them irresponsible. Anger 1 thus contrasts the calm, behavior-directed approach with the intense, person-directed approach depicted in Anger 2.

Anger 3 highlights the passive-aggressive approach: Analyst A vents their anger passive-aggressively rather than directly confronting the situation.

Sadness

Sadness 4. Analyst A tells Analyst B that they felt sad being left to do all of the work.

Analyst A says they thought they were in this together and that Analyst B's behavior made them feel like Analyst B doesn't care about them or their feelings.

Sadness 5. Feeling exhausted and let down, Analyst A tells Analyst B that they felt sad being left to do all of the work. Clearly holding back tears, Analyst A says they don't think it was fair for them to have to do the entire assignment.

Sadness 6. Analyst A tells Analyst B that they felt saddened and disheartened by Analyst B's behavior. They are part of a team and are in this together. Analyst A says staying up all night made them feel miserable.

We modeled our expressions of sadness around the idea that low-intensity, context-appropriate expressions of sadness can preserve perceived competence and status, whereas intense, uncontrolled displays diminish them (Côté & Hideg, 2011; Van Kleef, 2009, 2010). We chose these three sadness expressions based on research examining how different forms of sadness are perceived: controlled expressions of sadness may evoke sympathy and support, but uncontrolled displays can be perceived as unprofessional or manipulative (Graham et al., 2008). In Sadness 4 and Sadness 6, Analyst A controls their sadness and expresses it in a tempered way. By contrast, in Sadness 5, Analyst A's visible tears signal some loss of emotional control, reflecting a higher-intensity expression that is less likely to be perceived as appropriate at work. In short, Sadness 4 and Sadness 6 reflect tempered and measured expressions of sadness,

whereas the crying depicted in Sadness 5 is more intense and less obviously appropriate. Sadness 6, in particular, maintains its focus on Analyst B's *behavior*.

No Response

No Response 7. Analyst A chooses not to express their emotions because they don't want to make the situation worse and don't want to be accusatory or ruin their relationship with Analyst B.

No Response 8. Analyst A chooses not to express their emotions because they think doing so won't accomplish anything and would be unprofessional. Analyst A doesn't want to develop a reputation as an overly emotional person.

No Response 9. Analyst A chooses not to express their emotions because they think it would be healthier to simply let it go. Analyst A tries to think about the situation from Analyst B's perspective and decides that, if the situation were reversed, they would want Analyst B to treat them the same way.

We included the No Response category because choosing not to confront is arguably the modal response to this kind of conflict: when Fitness (2000) asked employees to recall a workplace anger episode, 42% reported withdrawing rather than confronting the offender. Employees stay silent to prevent escalation, to protect relationships, and to avoid being labeled negatively or facing uncontrollable negative social or career consequences (Bastiaensen et al., 2025; Hashemi & Shrivastava, 2024; Milliken et al., 2003). Prior research indicates that not expressing your emotions leads to lower social support, less closeness to others, and lower social satisfaction (Srivastava et al., 2009). All three No Response variants involve Analyst A choosing not to express their emotions, but for three different reasons. In No Response 7, Analyst A wants to maintain a positive relationship; in No Response 8, Analyst A does not want to damage their

reputation; in No Response 9, Analyst A does not see any benefit from expressing their emotions. These are all common reasons people choose not to respond in similar situations (Kish-Gephart et al., 2009; Milliken et al., 2003; Morrison & Milliken, 2000).

Method

Participants and Design

Participants were recruited via Amazon Mechanical Turk and randomly assigned to read the vignette selected from our pilot study along with one of the nine responses to the depicted conflict, in a between-subjects design. After excluding participants who failed attention checks or spent less than two minutes on the vignette and survey measures, we analyzed a final sample of 356 participants (145 female; M age = 36.75, SD = 11.80). Randomization checks confirmed that participant age and gender were balanced across conditions (all $ps > .05$).

Materials and Measures

The vignette described how Analyst A had to complete an urgent project overnight because Analyst B failed to do their share. To identify the most representative emotion expressions, we developed and tested the nine distinct responses described above (three variations each of anger, sadness, and no response), varying in intensity and directness. Data from our pilot study confirmed that the depicted conflict was seen as serious, common, and emotionally evocative.

We selected six outcome dimensions commonly used in emotion perception and workplace behavior research (Brescoll & Uhlmann, 2008; Diefendorff et al., 2011; Fiske et al., 2002; Tiedens, 2001; Van Kleef, 2009; Van Kleef & Côté, 2018). These metrics capture both instrumental and relational outcomes. Participants read one of the nine responses attributed to Analyst A and rated the expresser on six key outcomes using 11-point scales (1 = *very little*, 11 =

very much): predicted behavior change, perceived effectiveness, perceived appropriateness, perceived agency, likability, and perceived status.

Although predicted behavior change and perceived effectiveness are highly correlated ($r = .60$), they are intended to evaluate different aspects of the response. Perceived effectiveness measured participants' global evaluation of the response's efficacy, whereas predicted behavior change specifically measured the anticipated influence of the response on the target's future actions.

Procedure and Analysis

Participants first read the vignette and the assigned response, then completed the rating scales in random order. We conducted a series of one-way ANOVAs with response type as the independent variable and each of the six outcomes as the dependent variable. We conducted a within-category analysis first, comparing variants of the same response category to identify the highest-rated variant within each category. We then compared the highest-rated responses from each category against one another.

Results

Within-Category Comparisons

We first analyzed differences within each category to identify the most effective exemplars. As shown in Table 1, Calm Anger (Anger 1) significantly outperformed the high-intensity and passive-aggressive variants across all instrumental outcomes ($ps < .039$). Similarly, Tempered Sadness (Sadness 6) was rated most favorably on appropriateness ($p = .026$). No significant differences appeared among the No Response variants. Consequently, we selected Calm Anger, Tempered Sadness, and Apprehensive Silence (No Response 8) as the focal stimuli for Study 2. These within-category form effects support Hypothesis 1.

Insert Table 1 about here

Between-Category Comparisons

We next compared these three focal responses against one another ($n = 129$). A one-way ANOVA revealed a significant effect of response type on perceived effectiveness, $F(2, 126) = 7.76, p = .001$. Calm Anger received the highest rating ($M = 8.38, SD = 1.87$), followed closely by Tempered Sadness ($M = 7.49, SD = 2.68$), with No Response rated lowest ($M = 6.19, SD = 2.99$). Both emotion expressions were rated as significantly more effective than No Response; the contrast between Calm Anger and Tempered Sadness was only marginal, $t(126) = 1.62, p = .11$.

Tempered Sadness emerged as a highly beneficial response in both the instrumental and relational domains. Calm Anger scored highest on the instrumental metrics: relative to Tempered Sadness, it was rated significantly higher on predicted behavior change, $t(126) = 3.30, p = .001$, and perceived agency, $t(126) = 2.64, p = .009$, and marginally higher on perceived effectiveness. The two responses were statistically indistinguishable on perceived status, $t(126) = 0.77, p = .44$. On the relational outcomes, Tempered Sadness significantly outperformed Calm Anger on likability, $t(126) = 3.77, p < .001$, and the two were rated as similarly appropriate, $t(126) = 0.29, p = .77$. Calm Anger and Tempered Sadness also both significantly outperformed No Response on predicted behavior change, perceived agency, and perceived status (all $ps \leq .04$), supporting Hypothesis 2. The overall pattern likewise supports Hypothesis 3: Tempered Sadness matched or exceeded Calm Anger on the relational outcomes while approaching it on the instrumental ones.

Discussion

Study 1 investigated the *form* of emotion expressions, which shapes their effects. Within-category analyses revealed that, although anger is often assumed to be the most agentic response, only a calm, behavior-focused anger (Anger 1, Calm Anger) yielded uniformly positive instrumental outcomes; uncontrolled or passive-aggressive expressions backfired. We identified Anger 1 (Calm Anger), Sadness 6 (Tempered Sadness), and No Response 8 (Apprehensive Silence) as the strongest responses within their respective categories.

Between-category analyses clarify how each response type performs when the best-case variants are compared against one another. Most notably, sadness emerges as a powerful and effective response to workplace conflict. The Tempered Sadness response achieved instrumental outcomes approaching those of the best-case anger response while outperforming anger on likability and matching it on appropriateness. Choosing not to respond, though often seen as a safe and professional choice, was unambiguously the least effective approach to addressing workplace conflict across all measures except likability – and even on likability, it was not the most likable.

Our results imply that associations like anger-as-dominance and sadness-as-submission are not as strong as one might traditionally assume. When emotions are expressed in a measured, contextually appropriate way, both anger and sadness can be appropriate and effective. Sadness, in particular, might even be one of the most likable ways to respond, period. These findings set the stage for Study 2, where we used the three best-case exemplars (Calm Anger, Tempered Sadness, and Apprehensive Silence) to test whether the expresser's gender moderates observers' perceptions.

Study 2: Gender and Our Evolving Understanding of Emotions

Study 1 established that expressing anger or sadness to address workplace conflict significantly outperforms choosing not to respond, and that sadness is surprisingly powerful, performing almost as well as anger on instrumental measures (agency, behavior change, effectiveness, status) and exceeding anger on the relational outcome of likability while matching it on appropriateness. Study 2 asks whether those evaluations hold when the expresser's gender is known. In exploratory analyses, we also examined whether observers' age was associated with how anger and sadness were interpreted across male versus female expressers; we emphasize that these age analyses were not hypothesized at the outset but emerged during post hoc exploration of the data.

There is a voluminous literature suggesting that gender influences how emotions are perceived (Brescoll & Uhlmann, 2008; Heilman & Okimoto, 2007; Hess et al., 2004, 2009; Lewis, 2000; Marshburn et al., 2020; Plant et al., 2000; Rudman & Phelan, 2008; Schaubroeck & Shao, 2012). For example, in a job interview context, Brescoll and Uhlmann (2008) found that men who expressed anger were conferred significantly higher status than were women who expressed anger. They also found that women who expressed sadness were conferred higher status than women who expressed anger, but even when women expressed sadness, they were still conferred lower status than men who expressed anger. In a later study, Brescoll and colleagues (2018) found that women who were perceived as agentic were more likely to engender "moral outrage" when participants were primed to feel disgust than women who were perceived as communal. The authors argued that agentic women leaders trigger moral outrage because they violate the gender status hierarchy. Similarly, Heilman and colleagues (2004) found that women whose jobs were characterized as masculine were seen as significantly less likable

than men in comparable jobs who received identical evaluations. Based on these and other similar findings, researchers have argued that women experience backlash when they are perceived to violate prescriptive gender norms, such as those characterizing anger as masculine – especially if they do so in occupations perceived as masculine.

Many of the studies that have found backlash effects on women, however, have focused on leadership roles (Brescoll, 2016; Brescoll et al., 2018; Eagly & Karau, 2002; Heilman, 2001; Heilman et al., 2004; Lyness & Judiesch, 1999). Whether similar penalties apply to women working in less senior roles remains unclear. More recent evidence shows a cultural shift and suggests the backlash effect may not be universal to agentic women. Several studies show that agentic women can receive benefits rather than backlash. One study found that top women leaders were perceived to be even more agentic than top men leaders and, crucially, that they were also perceived as warmer, friendlier, more caring, and more good-natured (Rosette & Tost, 2010). Another found that “masculine” (high in aggressiveness, low in supportiveness) women high on self-monitoring received more promotions than women who were low on self-monitoring, low on masculinity, or low on both (O’Neill & O’Reilly, 2011). Encouragingly, the overlap between stereotypically masculine traits and leadership stereotypes has decreased over time (Koenig et al., 2011).

These findings imply that perceptions of agency and warmth among women leaders have become more flexible over time. Recent cross-national research indicates a broader global decline in sexism, though hostile and benevolent forms remain interlinked across cultures (Hammond et al., 2025). As instrumental and relational evaluations grow less tightly bound to gender expectations, cultural stereotypes linking agentic behavior to masculinity may be loosening. And as workplaces diversify and emotional intelligence gains more explicit value

(Hamedani et al., 2024), it has become increasingly possible for women to be perceived as both agentic and communal, and for men to display warmth and sadness without facing a raised eyebrow. In other words, contextual appropriateness, rather than gender, may drive how workplace emotions are judged.

If agency is an important trait for both men and women on their path to becoming leaders (Badura et al., 2018; Ely et al., 2011; Judge et al., 2002; Rosette & Tost, 2010; Tremmel & Wahl, 2023; Vial & Napier, 2018), when does agency become detrimental for women but not men? Under what conditions do women's agentic behaviors stop eliciting backlash and start being interpreted as competence or authenticity?

Study 2 tests whether contextually appropriate emotion expressions override gender stereotypes in the masculine, high-pressure setting of investment banking. Using the three highest-rated responses (Calm Anger, Tempered Sadness, and Apprehensive Silence), we examine how response type and expresser gender interact to shape perceptions of agency, effectiveness, appropriateness, likability, and status. Building on previous work showing backlash against stereotype-incongruent emotion expressions (e.g., sad men, angry women; Brescoll, 2016; Brescoll & Uhlmann, 2008; Brescoll et al., 2018; Cheshin, 2020; Heilman, 2001; Heilman et al., 2004; Porat & Levy Paluck, 2024; Tiedens, 2001; Tiedens et al., 2000), we test whether contextual appropriateness mitigates backlash, regardless of gender: women expressing anger will be perceived as agentic and effective as men expressing anger (instrumental outcomes), and men expressing sadness will be viewed as appropriate and likable as women expressing sadness (relational outcomes). Our formal prediction (Hypothesis 4) concerns the instrumental family, where role congruity theory and the EASI account make opposing predictions.

Method

To test these hypotheses, we adapted the vignette from Study 1 to include the expresser's gender. Using the three highest-rated responses from Study 1 – Calm Anger (Anger 1), Tempered Sadness (Sadness 6), and Apprehensive Silence (No Response 8), which we refer to hereafter simply as Anger, Sadness, and No Response – we examined whether the perceived instrumental and relational outcomes of emotion expression interacted with the expresser's gender. If contextual appropriateness drives evaluation independent of gender, then the pattern of outcomes should hold across genders.

Participants and Design

After applying the same quality-control criteria used in Study 1, a final sample of 570 participants recruited from Amazon Mechanical Turk was analyzed (276 women; M age = 41.51, SD = 12.88). Participants were randomly assigned to one of six conditions in a 3 (Response Type: Anger, Sadness, No Response) $\times$ 2 (Expresser Gender: Female, Male) between-subjects factorial design. The number of male and female participants was approximately equal in all conditions.

Materials and Measures

Study 2 presented an adapted version of the vignette used in Study 1, replacing “Analyst A” with “Alex” and “Analyst B” with “Brian.” We manipulated the expresser's gender by changing only the pronouns used to refer to Alex (he/him vs. she/her) in the vignette and survey items (see Appendix), ensuring that any differences can be attributed to gender alone. Participants read the vignette paired with one of the six possible response-by-gender combinations, then rated the expresser on the same outcomes as in Study 1. Item order was randomized.

All measures used 11-point scales (1 = *not at all*, 11 = *extremely*), identical to Study 1, and multi-item scales were averaged. We added two items (reasonable and justified) to our measure of appropriateness to capture a more nuanced scope of situational variability within the anger and sadness conditions (Cronbach's $\alpha = .90$). The multi-item scales showed reliability comparable to Study 1, allowing instrumental and relational outcomes to be compared directly across the two studies. We grouped the outcomes into two families: instrumental (predicted behavior change, perceived effectiveness, agency, perceived status) and relational (appropriateness, likability).

Analytic Approach

Our primary models were 3 (Response Type) $\times$ 2 (Expresser Gender) factorial ANOVAs, estimated separately for each dependent variable, with post hoc pairwise comparisons following any significant interaction. Because Study 1 showed that outcomes clustered into distinct instrumental and relational families, we also tested whether expresser gender moderated the effects of response type within each family. Participants' age was recorded as a continuous variable and analyzed as such in exploratory models testing whether age moderated evaluations of anger, sadness, and no response. For the figures only, we grouped age into bins to aid visual interpretation.

Results

Study 2 examined whether evaluations of anger, sadness, and no response shifted once the expresser's gender was known and, in exploratory analyses, whether observer age moderated these effects.

Main Effects of Response Type and Gender

Across all measures, response type produced large effects (all $ps < .001$). Consistent with the patterns found in Study 1, both anger and sadness outperformed no response across instrumental (effectiveness, behavior change, agency, status) and relational (likability, appropriateness) outcomes, and they did so for both female and male expressers.

Consistent with our hypotheses, gender effects were generally minimal. Perceived status showed a small male advantage in the descriptive means (Table 2), but gender did not reliably produce differences across the other measures. These small effects suggest that contextually appropriate emotion expressions largely override gender stereotypes in workplace conflict and that women were evaluated comparably to men. In the anger condition, female and male expressers were evaluated similarly across outcomes: for example, appropriateness was high for both (female: $M = 9.85$, $SD = 1.95$; male: $M = 9.58$, $SD = 1.97$), as was perceived agency (female: $M = 9.07$, $SD = 1.93$; male: $M = 8.93$, $SD = 1.77$).

Insert Table 2 about here

Gender $\times$ Response Type Interactions

Overall, gender differences were small. Across outcomes, anger and sadness were both rated more favorably than no response for both female and male expressers. Evidence for gender moderation was limited: the only clear difference emerged for appropriateness, where sadness was rated especially appropriate when expressed by women. We used regression analyses to test interaction effects (Table 3).

Insert Table 3 about here

Consistent with Study 1, the type of emotional response drove evaluations, while the interaction between gender and emotion was largely nonsignificant. On appropriateness, however, the Female $\times$ Sadness interaction was significant ($b = 1.36, p < .01$). As shown in Figure 1, participants rated sadness as more appropriate when expressed by women ($M = 10.20, SD = 1.21$), though it remained highly appropriate when expressed by men ($M = 9.45, SD = 1.90$). In contrast, no response was rated as slightly more appropriate for male expressers ($M = 7.90$) than female expressers ($M = 7.28$). Anger showed little gender difference ($p > .10$), indicating that anger expression was not viewed as inappropriate for either gender in this context.

Insert Figure 1 about here

A significant interaction also emerged for likability ($b = 0.87, p < .05$): while sadness enhanced likability for both genders, the effect was stronger for female expressers. Anger was associated with reduced likability for both genders, whereas sadness modestly enhanced likability, particularly when expressed by women. Likability captures relational costs that may accompany instrumental gains, allowing us to examine whether effective responses undermine interpersonal relations.

Across all instrumental outcomes (effectiveness, agency, behavior change, status), gender did not moderate the effect of response type, supporting Hypothesis 4. The interactions reached significance only for the relational outcomes: although sadness was judged appropriate whether

expressed by men or women, it was rated especially appropriate coming from women, suggesting that women may be rewarded somewhat more than men for the same expression of sadness.

Exploratory Analysis: Participant Age × Expresser Gender × Response Type

We also examined whether observer age influenced evaluations (Table 4). While the main results held across the sample, a three-way interaction (Age × Gender × Response Type) suggested a generational divergence: older participants tended to rate angry women less favorably on agency and effectiveness compared to angry men, whereas younger participants showed no such bias. This suggests that although contextual appropriateness drives evaluations overall, traditional gender stereotypes may still be present among older cohorts. We reiterate that these analyses were exploratory.

 Insert Table 4 and Figure 2 about here

Discussion

Study 2 confirms the Study 1 pattern: when the response fits the context, expressing anger or sadness is judged far more effective and appropriate than staying silent. Across every outcome, the main effect of response type overrode any effect of gender.

Contrary to classic theories predicting backlash for “angry women” or “sad men” (Brescoll & Uhlmann, 2008), we found no significant gender differences in how these emotions were evaluated on instrumental outcomes. No overall main effect of expresser gender emerged, though some outcomes showed modest Response × Gender patterning. Female expressers of anger were seen as just as effective, agentic, likable, and appropriate as male colleagues who did

the same. The exceptions were relational: sadness was rated especially appropriate – and somewhat more likable – when expressed by women, though it remained highly appropriate and likable for men as well. Beyond that, gender did not moderate evaluations.

Exploratory analyses suggested that, while most Age $\times$ Gender $\times$ Response Type interactions were nonsignificant for the relational outcomes, older participants tended to react less favorably to anger expressed by women on the instrumental outcomes. Contextual appropriateness still carried substantially more weight than demographic factors in shaping evaluations of negative emotion expressions. These findings suggest that when anger or sadness is an appropriate reaction to a workplace conflict, women are not penalized for expressing it, and men do not automatically gain an advantage.

General Discussion

Across two studies, we challenged classic assumptions about anger and sadness in workplace conflict. While anger emerged as the most agentic and behavior-changing emotion, aligning with prior literature linking anger to perceptions of competence, dominance, and social status or power (Brescoll & Uhlmann, 2008; Tiedens, 2001; Van Kleef, 2010), our findings also qualify this classic picture: only mild, calm anger directed at the offending behavior produced uniformly positive reactions. Person-directed, hostile anger undermined the goals of conflict resolution. Moreover, sadness's likability advantage over anger only widened as anger grew harsher: in the within-anger comparisons, participants rated responders who expressed less regulated anger as less effective, less likable, and lower in status than those who used the more controlled anger variant or the tempered forms of sadness. Thus, while anger can indeed be a powerful catalyst for change, our studies show that the power of anger depends on whether it is expressed in a controlled, contextually appropriate way.

Our findings also spotlight the surprising power of sadness. Prior research has shown that displays of sadness can sometimes be *more* effective than displays of anger in securing cooperation, by invoking empathy rather than intimidation (Côté & Hideg, 2011; Sinaceur & Tiedens, 2006; Van Kleef et al., 2006, 2010). Our results show that a tempered, authentic expression of sadness achieved roughly 90% of the perceived effectiveness of anger (M Tempered Sadness / M Calm Anger = 89.4%) and nearly 85% of its perceived agency while avoiding the social penalties associated with confrontation. This challenges the binary view that leaders must choose between being “tough” (i.e., angry) or “liked” (i.e., choosing not to confront the situation). Sadness may allow for both. A sad response, when delivered sincerely and mindfully, appears to effectively address the problem without damaging relationships.

Finally, our results speak to gender dynamics (or the lack thereof) in emotion expressions at work, as well as intriguing exploratory generational shifts in these dynamics that may inform future research. Surprisingly, we found no evidence of backlash against angry women. The only gender differences were relational: women were rated as more likable, and their sadness as especially appropriate, when they expressed sadness. Contrary to classic expectations of a double standard, men and women who expressed anger or sadness were judged similarly in terms of effectiveness, competence, likability, and status. This pattern held across both instrumental and relational evaluations, offering a counterpoint to longstanding beliefs that “angry women” are penalized at work or that “sad men” are seen as weak. In fact, our data align with recent evidence that, in contemporary workplaces, observers do not necessarily reward men or punish women for the same emotional displays (Porat & Levy Paluck, 2024). This finding qualifies longstanding claims that identical emotional behavior yields opposite outcomes for women and men, suggesting that such gendered reactions may be more context-dependent and less universal than

previously assumed (Brescoll & Uhlmann, 2008). Classic studies demonstrated that an angry man was often seen as competent and conferred higher status (Tiedens, 2001; Tiedens et al., 2000), while an angry woman suffered backlash – deemed less competent, less likable, lower in status, and unprofessional (Brescoll & Uhlmann, 2008; Tiedens, 2001). Likewise, men showing sadness were historically viewed less favorably than women doing so: in an employment context, crying men are often viewed as less competent than crying women (Fischer et al., 2013).

Our results suggest that these gendered scripts may be changing. The absence of broad gender effects implies a possible cultural shift, in which many people today may be evaluating emotion expressions through a more gender-neutral lens, focusing more on the content and context of the emotion than on the speaker's gender. We did see some exploratory evidence of gender-stereotyped evaluations of anger, however: older observers reacted less favorably to anger expressed by women, whereas younger observers showed little such bias. Overall, these patterns suggest that workplace norms may be evolving toward greater equality in emotional agency, validating calls for both men and women to be “allowed” a full range of emotions at work. The important consideration is not the gender of the expresser but rather the appropriateness of the emotion in context and the tradeoff between instrumental outcomes (on which anger has a slight advantage) and relational outcomes (on which sadness has the clear advantage).

The Manner and Form of Emotion Expression

Our findings demonstrate that emotion expressions in conflict are highly context-dependent and that the manner and form of expression can make the difference between effective resolution and counterproductive escalation. Despite anger's reputation as a “powerful” emotion, expressions of anger that cross into personal hostility or appear uncontrolled are often viewed as

inappropriate, overreactive, and harmful to workplace goals (Callister et al., 2017; Cheshin, 2020; Gibson et al., 2009; Van't Riet et al., 2018). These harsh perceptions help explain why indiscriminate anger tends to undermine the responder's effectiveness and status (Callister et al., 2017; Gibson et al., 2009; Tiedens, 2001), as the responses to Anger 2 and Anger 3 in Study 1 illustrate. Consistent with the dual threshold model of anger expression (Gibson & Callister, 2010), only low-intensity, controlled anger expressions led to uniformly positive outcomes in Study 1, whereas high-intensity or norm-violating anger was counterproductive. These results suggest that voicing anger in a civil, problem-focused manner can harness anger's benefits without incurring interpersonal penalties. By contrast, yelling, insulting, or stewing in silent resentment fails both tests of appropriateness and effectiveness.

Our findings agree with prior observations that anger is most constructive when directed at the target's behavior (i.e., is not personal), delivered with low intensity, and expressed in settings where anger is an understandable response (Callister et al., 2017; Cheshin, 2020; Gibson et al., 2009; Steinel et al., 2008; Van't Riet et al., 2018). When these conditions are met (as with Anger 1), anger can actually improve conflict outcomes and be seen as a reasonable, even positive, response to wrongdoing. Thus, manner and form dominate the interpersonal effects of the expressed emotion: anger is not a guaranteed boon or bane – it is the way anger is framed and delivered that determines its impact. This differs from much of the research on the interpersonal consequences of negative emotion expression, which tends to treat expressed emotions categorically. Anger can have quite positive effects, but it can also backfire.

The effectiveness of sadness in prompting change might be explained by the social information it conveys. A sad response to conflict often signals that one is disappointed or hurt rather than aggressive (Sinaceur et al., 2015; Van Kleef et al., 2006), placing the weight on the

wrongdoer to remedy the situation out of conscience or empathy. Our participants perceived sadness as reasonably agentic (well above the midpoint of our perceived agency scale) and highly likable, illustrating the power of what might be called “sympathy leverage” in conflict. This aligns with negotiation research showing that expressions of sadness can elicit greater concession-making from counterparts by making them feel more sympathy and concern for the expresser (Sinaceur et al., 2015). Importantly, sadness offered a dual benefit: it performed nearly as well as anger on instrumental outcomes while fostering greater goodwill on relational ones. Our investigation focused on the interpersonal consequences of these expressions rather than on the observer’s internal affective states. As a result, although our findings are consistent with a mechanism of sympathy or guilt, we did not measure these states directly. Future research should establish whether compliance is driven by observer sympathy, as we suspect, or by other inferential processes.

These findings challenge a simplistic dominance model of conflict (in which only anger shows strength) and instead support a more nuanced view of emotional agency. One can assert authority through calm resolve or heartfelt disappointment – it need not be through fury. By expressing genuine sadness about a problem, a leader or employee might communicate how seriously they value the issue (implying high standards and commitment) without resorting to intimidation. This strategy can “call in” colleagues to resolve a problem rather than “calling them out” harshly, thereby addressing the issue with less collateral damage to trust and team cohesion.

Challenging Classic Assumptions About Dominance and Agency

Taken together, these findings invite a reconsideration of traditional assumptions about which emotions denote strength and effectiveness in the workplace. Classic portrayals of “agentic” emotions have overwhelmingly centered on anger, casting it as the emotional language

of dominance, assertiveness, and competence (Brescoll & Uhlmann, 2008; Gibson & Callister, 2010; Tiedens, 2001; Van Kleef, 2008, 2010). By contrast, emotions like sadness have often been stereotyped as “weak” or submissive and thus assumed to be ill-suited to influencing others or asserting one’s will. Our research echoes other findings that challenge this dichotomy. Yes, anger signals agency – our participants tended to believe expressing anger would be the response most likely to change the target’s behavior – but this advantage was clear only for the best-case version of anger; other forms of anger held no advantage over sadness on instrumental outcomes. In addition, sadness proved to be a “powerful” emotion in its own right. In our data, a sad response garnered almost 90% of the instrumental benefits (behavior change, agency, and effectiveness) achieved by the most effective anger response, while better preserving likability, appearing similarly appropriate, and being conferred high status. This directly contradicts the notion that anger uniquely conveys strength.

Importantly, our gender findings challenge the assumption that agency and emotion expressions are gender stereotyped. Historically, anger has been culturally coded as a masculine “high-power” emotion and sadness as a feminine “low-power” emotion (Brescoll & Uhlmann, 2008; Tiedens, 2001; Tiedens et al., 2000). Women who wielded anger were often punished for violating their expected communal role, and men who showed sadness or vulnerability risked being seen as too weak. Our results show an attenuation of these gendered expectations across the majority of our study participants. But we did observe one boundary condition: older participants tended to rate angry women less favorably than angry men, whereas younger participants showed little such bias. In other words, the classic stereotype-driven reactions surfaced primarily among older participants. This generational divergence, while not the core focus of our studies, is noteworthy. It suggests that the well-documented “anger penalty” for

women and “sadness penalty” for men have not vanished entirely but may be fading with newer generations. Older individuals who came of age in a time of stricter gender roles might still consciously or unconsciously apply those outdated templates when evaluating emotional behavior. Younger individuals, by contrast, appear more accustomed to egalitarian norms in emotional expression. This shift across age cohorts aligns with the idea of a gradual cultural evolution in expectations: as societal views on gender and emotion continue to progress, we may see a future in which an “angry woman” or a “tearful man” raises few eyebrows and carries little stigma. Instead, appropriateness in context will carry the day.

Our data provide an optimistic glimpse of that future, even as they remind us that some lingering biases remain. We frame these age-related results as exploratory but illuminating: they suggest cultural norms around gender are gradually reshaping longstanding gender-based stereotypes, although definitive conclusions await future research designed specifically to test these generational dynamics.

Contextual Appropriateness of Emotion Expression in Conflict Resolution

Another significant theme from this research is the importance of contextual appropriateness when choosing how to respond to workplace conflicts. Emotions do not exist in a vacuum; the same expression can be judged very differently depending on timing, place, and manner (Cheshin, 2020; Diefendorff et al., 2011; Van Kleef, 2009, 2010). Our Anger 1 condition – calm, focused anger – can be viewed as a case of maximized appropriateness in context: the emotion was delivered at the right intensity, focused on the right target (the problem), and justified by the circumstances. As a result, it was rewarded with higher status conferral, higher perceived effectiveness, a higher perceived likelihood of changing the target’s behavior, and even reasonably high likability ratings. The less appropriate forms of anger we studied either

overstepped boundaries by attacking the person or sidestepped direct communication by being covertly hostile; they were comparatively inappropriate and thus ineffective.

Our research supports a growing recognition in organizational psychology that effective conflict resolution is about emotion articulation, not emotion suppression (Cheshin, 2020; Grandey, 2003; Hülshager & Schewe, 2011; Srivastava et al., 2009; Van Kleef, 2008, 2009, 2010). The goal is not to have no emotions, but to appropriately, constructively, and authentically express the emotions you feel (Cheshin, 2020; Diefendorff et al., 2011; Van't Riet et al., 2018). Emotions are signals, and the information in the signal can be received only if some form of the emotion is expressed (Frijda, 1986; Van Kleef, 2008, 2009, 2010; Van Kleef & Côté, 2018). The success of sadness in our studies, alongside the conditional success of anger, emphasizes that there is more than one emotional path to resolving conflict. By embracing emotional authenticity and ensuring the expression aligns with the context, individuals can resolve conflicts in a manner that both addresses the immediate issue and preserves (or even strengthens) working relationships.

Limitations

Two limitations bearing on our design choices deserve note. First, our No Response conditions stated Analyst A's reason for staying silent. Stating the motive was necessary for experimental control – and the three motives we tested did not differ on any outcome in Study 1 – but it departs from naturalistic silence, in which observers typically cannot know why a colleague said nothing and may project motives of their own. The evaluations of silence reported here are therefore best understood as evaluations of silence whose rationale is known; unexplained silence in the field may be received differently, although it is not obvious that ambiguity would improve its reception.

Second, our a priori classification of perceived status as an instrumental outcome, while grounded in status conferral research (Tiedens, 2001; Tiedens et al., 2000), simplifies a construct with a relational face: status is granted by observers, and it plausibly tracks whether the expresser behaved acceptably as well as whether the expresser can get results. Our substantive conclusions do not hinge on this classification – status showed no reliable difference between Calm Anger and Tempered Sadness in Study 1, and in Study 2 gender did not moderate status for either expression – but future work might treat status as a bridge between the instrumental and relational families rather than as a member of either.

Conclusion

These studies advance our understanding of emotion expressions as sophisticated communication tools. They support the commonsense view that *what* emotion one expresses, *how* one expresses it, and *the interaction* between the expression and the context profoundly shape its interpersonal effects. Anger, often a sign of strength, is indeed effective at changing behavior, but it must be expressed mindfully to avoid interpersonal damage. Sadness, often shunned in professional contexts, proved to be a quietly effective response that promoted instrumental outcomes without sacrificing relational ones. Together, these findings offer a way to rethink traditional advice around workplace emotions. Rather than simply encouraging employees to “be assertive” (implicitly endorsing strategic anger) or to “stay positive” (i.e., avoid negative emotions altogether), the nuanced message is to be genuine yet mindful of context: express the emotion that truly reflects the situation, and do so in a manner that respects context and norms. Such an approach fosters integrity and situational appropriateness, which our research shows are rewarded with greater cooperation and esteem.

By challenging classic assumptions about dominance and emotion, our work also reflects broader cultural currents. The largely gender-neutral reactions to anger and sadness in our data hint at an organizational culture moving toward more egalitarian emotional norms, in which contextual appropriateness is valued over antiquated gender prescriptions. At the same time, the generational hints of bias remind us that this evolution is ongoing: awareness and continued effort are needed to fully dispel stereotype-based reactions where they linger.

The ability to express emotions authentically and appropriately at work is a critical component of healthy conflict resolution and effective leadership. Our findings suggest that employees and leaders alike can navigate conflicts successfully by being true to their emotions and respectful of others. Negative emotion expressions, when aligned with the context, are not outbursts or signs of weakness; they are potent signals and social tools. In the modern workplace, anger and sadness each have their place in addressing conflict. Anger prioritizes instrumental outcomes, whereas sadness balances instrumental outcomes with relational ones. The decision to express one over the other comes down to which side of the ledger matters more in context.

Research Transparency Statement

[To be completed before submission] Preregistration: [State status]. Materials: All study stimuli (the conflict vignette and the nine response manipulations) are reported in full in the manuscript; complete survey materials are available at [anonymized repository link]. Data and analysis scripts: De-identified data and analysis scripts for all studies are available at [anonymized repository link].

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Table 1*Within-Category Comparisons of Emotional Expression Variants (Study 1)***Panel A: Anger Variants (1–3)**

Outcome	Anger 1	Anger 2	Anger 3	<i>F</i> (2, 118)	<i>p</i>	η^2
Appropriateness	9.76 (0.27)	7.91 (0.47)	7.31 (0.47)	9.53	< .001	.139
Effectiveness	8.38 (0.29)	6.36 (0.47)	6.09 (0.56)	7.94	< .001	.119
Agency	9.08 (0.28)	8.73 (0.27)	7.08 (0.45)	9.76	< .001	.142
Behavior change	8.48 (0.27)	7.26 (0.42)	6.63 (0.50)	5.33	.006	.083
Likability	8.18 (0.31)	6.40 (0.39)	7.16 (0.48)	5.55	.005	.086
Status	8.66 (0.26)	7.49 (0.34)	8.12 (0.40)	3.34	.039	.054

Note. Values are means with standard errors in parentheses. Selected: Anger 1 (Calm Anger), a calm, behavior-focused confrontation emphasizing team standards. Anger 2 depicts high-intensity, person-directed hostility (yelling, personal insults); Anger 3 depicts passive-aggressive withdrawal (silent treatment, dirty looks).

Panel B: Sadness Variants (4–6)

Outcome	Sadness 4	Sadness 5	Sadness 6	<i>F</i> (2, 116)	<i>p</i>	η^2
Appropriateness	8.79 (0.43)	8.57 (0.44)	9.89 (0.26)	3.77	.026	.061
Effectiveness	6.97 (0.47)	7.14 (0.44)	7.49 (0.40)	0.39	.680	.007
Agency	6.67 (0.47)	6.88 (0.46)	7.68 (0.41)	1.52	.222	.026
Behavior change	5.69 (0.50)	7.13 (0.38)	6.64 (0.44)	2.51	.086	.041
Likability	9.03 (0.39)	8.79 (0.28)	9.60 (0.22)	2.00	.139	.033
Status	7.87 (0.47)	8.50 (0.31)	8.96 (0.25)	2.58	.080	.043

Note. Values are means with standard errors in parentheses. Selected: Sadness 6 (Tempered Sadness), a controlled admission of feeling disheartened and miserable regarding the team dynamic. Sadness 4 depicts relational disappointment focusing on lack of care; Sadness 5 depicts high-intensity distress with visible tears.

Panel C: No Response Variants (7–9)

Outcome	No Resp. 7	No Resp. 8	No Resp. 9	<i>F</i> (2, 113)	<i>p</i>	η^2
Appropriateness	6.30 (0.58)	7.33 (0.40)	6.80 (0.44)	1.17	.313	.020
Effectiveness	5.73 (0.60)	6.19 (0.46)	6.02 (0.52)	0.19	.827	.003
Agency	4.82 (0.51)	4.80 (0.42)	4.62 (0.38)	0.07	.933	.001
Behavior change	4.21 (0.53)	4.08 (0.44)	4.72 (0.50)	0.50	.610	.009
Likability	9.05 (0.40)	9.02 (0.28)	8.87 (0.33)	0.09	.915	.002
Status	7.26 (0.47)	7.77 (0.32)	7.34 (0.37)	0.54	.585	.009

Note. Values are means with standard errors in parentheses. Selected: No Response 8 (Apprehensive Silence), withholding expression to avoid reputation damage. No Response 7 depicts withholding expression to preserve the relationship; No Response 9 depicts withholding expression due to perspective taking and “letting it go.”

Table 2*Descriptive Statistics by Response Type and Expresser Gender (Study 2)*

Response type	Outcome	Female	Male
Anger	Appropriateness	9.85 (1.95)	9.58 (1.97)
	Effectiveness	7.81 (2.57)	7.52 (2.51)
	Agency	9.07 (1.93)	8.93 (1.77)
	Behavior change	7.66 (2.51)	7.26 (2.54)
	Likability	8.24 (2.36)	8.12 (1.95)
	Status	9.11 (1.86)	8.86 (1.90)
Sadness	Appropriateness	10.20 (1.21)	9.45 (1.90)
	Effectiveness	6.97 (2.81)	6.98 (2.87)
	Agency	7.63 (2.28)	6.94 (2.73)
	Behavior change	5.83 (2.83)	6.22 (2.66)
	Likability	9.19 (1.67)	8.73 (2.02)
	Status	9.04 (1.90)	8.61 (2.10)
No Response	Appropriateness	7.28 (2.43)	7.90 (2.44)
	Effectiveness	5.38 (3.36)	5.72 (3.37)
	Agency	4.85 (2.83)	5.14 (2.92)
	Behavior change	4.07 (2.86)	3.84 (3.13)
	Likability	8.71 (2.10)	9.12 (1.79)
	Status	8.30 (2.20)	7.89 (2.36)

Note. Values are means with standard deviations in parentheses, shown separately by response type (Anger, Sadness, No Response) and expresser gender. Statistical tests reported in the text are based on linear models with response type, expresser gender, and their interaction; pairwise contrasts compare Anger and Sadness to No Response within each gender. All outcome scales range from 1 to 11.

Table 3*Regression Coefficients Predicting Evaluative Outcomes From Response Type and Expresser**Gender (Study 2)*

Predictor	Appropriateness	Behavior change	Effectiveness	Status	Likability	Agency
Intercept	7.896*** (0.247)	3.838*** (0.316)	5.717*** (0.341)	7.889*** (0.239)	9.116*** (0.181)	5.141*** (0.295)
Female	−0.615 (0.353)	0.236 (0.433)	−0.334 (0.487)	0.409 (0.330)	−0.409 (0.283)	−0.290 (0.416)
Anger	1.688*** (0.325)	3.423*** (0.417)	1.806*** (0.434)	0.975** (0.314)	−0.997*** (0.276)	3.788*** (0.351)
Sadness	1.558*** (0.312)	2.382*** (0.413)	1.263** (0.446)	0.721* (0.318)	−0.386 (0.272)	1.796*** (0.403)
Female × Anger	0.887 (0.458)	0.162 (0.574)	0.620 (0.617)	−0.164 (0.434)	0.529 (0.429)	0.436 (0.500)
Female × Sadness	1.362** (0.420)	−0.630 (0.587)	0.323 (0.636)	0.026 (0.438)	0.873* (0.389)	0.987 (0.551)
Observations	570	570	570	570	570	570
R ²	.220	.216	.084	.043	.039	.311

Note. Entries are unstandardized coefficients with robust standard errors in parentheses. Anger and Sadness are dummy coded relative to a No Response baseline. Higher scores indicate more favorable evaluations of the expresser. [Significance stars to be verified against the merged data file; see revision memo.] * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

Table 4

Exploratory Models: Anger $\times$ Age $\times$ Female Predicting Evaluative Outcomes, With Sadness as the Baseline (Study 2)

Predictor	Appropriateness	Behavior change	Effectiveness	Status	Likability	Agency
Intercept	9.480*** (0.178)	6.155*** (0.261)	6.930*** (0.270)	8.634*** (0.193)	8.752*** (0.202)	6.909*** (0.222)
Anger	0.123 (0.260)	1.118** (0.381)	0.603 (0.393)	0.256 (0.282)	−0.619* (0.295)	2.045*** (0.324)
Age	0.024 (0.014)	−0.060** (0.020)	−0.046* (0.020)	0.022 (0.015)	0.020 (0.015)	−0.026 (0.017)
Female	0.720** (0.255)	−0.342 (0.373)	0.038 (0.386)	0.407 (0.276)	0.442 (0.289)	0.715* (0.317)
Anger $\times$ Age	0.009 (0.020)	0.080** (0.029)	0.064* (0.030)	0.023 (0.022)	0.003 (0.023)	0.068** (0.025)
Anger $\times$ Female	−0.457 (0.367)	0.776 (0.537)	0.265 (0.555)	−0.163 (0.398)	−0.318 (0.417)	−0.582 (0.457)
Age $\times$ Female	−0.023 (0.021)	0.085** (0.030)	0.046 (0.031)	−0.016 (0.022)	−0.017 (0.023)	0.045 (0.026)
Anger $\times$ Age $\times$ Female	−0.019 (0.029)	−0.146*** (0.042)	−0.089* (0.043)	−0.052 (0.031)	−0.019 (0.033)	−0.098** (0.036)
Observations	377	377	377	377	377	377
R ²	.048	.112	.036	.044	.054	.163

Note. Entries are unstandardized coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. The intercept represents a male expresser of Sadness at the mean participant age. These models are exploratory. [Significance stars to be verified against the merged data file; see revision memo.] * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

Figure Captions

Figure 1. Gender $\times$ Response Type interaction across outcomes. Mean ratings ($\pm SE$) for six outcomes by expresser gender and response type. Stars indicate within-gender planned contrasts comparing Anger and Sadness to No Response ($p < .05$, $p < .01$, $p < .001$). Higher scores indicate more favorable evaluations. [Figure file to be inserted at production quality.]

Figure 2. Exploratory Age $\times$ Gender $\times$ Response Type effects on appropriateness ratings. Lines and shaded ribbons represent model-predicted appropriateness ratings ($\pm 95\%$ confidence intervals) from a linear regression including Response Type (Anger, Sadness, No Response), Expresser Gender (Female, Male), Participant Age (continuous), and all interactions. Points and error bars show binned means (8 quantile bins) $\pm 1 SE$ for visualization only; statistical inference is based on the full individual-level model rather than the binned data. Although age-related trends appear visually distinct across response types and genders, the three-way interaction on appropriateness was not statistically significant; a marginal Expresser Gender $\times$ Age interaction indicates modest age-related divergence between male and female expressers overall. [Figure file to be inserted at production quality.]

Appendix

Study 2 Stimuli

Participants read the following scenario. The expresser's gender was manipulated by changing only the pronouns referring to Alex (she/her vs. he/him) in the vignette and survey items; the female-expresser version is shown here.

An investment banking team is working on a pitch book for a prospective client. The work is tedious, and two first-year analysts, Alex and Brian, decide to split the work. The evening before the deadline, Alex finds out that Brian has barely completed his portion. Since Brian has already left the office and cannot be reached, Alex stays all night to complete the assignment alone.

Anger (calm, stern, and behavior-focused). Alex feels angry and tells Brian that this behavior is not acceptable. She tells him that they are part of a team and team members cannot behave like this. Alex emphasizes she wants to have a good relationship with Brian but also makes it clear that she will not tolerate this behavior in the future.

Sadness (tempered and authentic). Alex tells Brian that she felt saddened and disheartened by Brian's behavior. They are part of a team and are in this together. Alex says staying up all night made her feel miserable.

No Response (apprehensive silence). Alex chooses not to express her emotions to Brian because she thinks doing so won't accomplish anything and would be unprofessional. Alex doesn't want to develop a reputation as an overly emotional person.